

Belly · Knee · Feet

A pragmatic three-stage pumpfoil learning guide — from the floor up. By Zeno Davatz, pump.zuerich.

This approach is for the broad majority of learners. Three stages, in this order: **belly** → **knee** → **feet**. The whole purpose of stages 1 and 2 is to build one thing: the feeling of *gliding with a low centre of gravity*. Once the student owns that feeling, the rest follows.

Stage 1 — Belly

1 Around 20 to 100 attempts lying flat on the board.

- Lie prone, body close to the deck, weight centred over the mast.
- Glide as far as you can after each push or pull.
- No standing, no kneeling. The only goal is to feel the foil carry you.

Why so many tries? Because the glide feeling at low centre of gravity is what every later stage stands on. Skip it and you build on sand.

Stage 2 — Knees

2 Another 20 to 100 attempts on the knees.

- Push off, settle one knee down, then the second.
- Once balanced, pump the board.
- You're still low — but higher than on the belly. The balance task gets a step harder.

Readiness signal — when to move on: Once the student can glide **2–5 metres or more** on the belly *and* on the knees, the glide feeling at low centre of gravity is there. That's the cue for the next step — not a fixed number of attempts.

Stage 3 — Feet

3 Stand up — but only when the student wants to.

- The student must *want* to go to the feet. Pushed transitions don't stick.
- Get up from a knee start; no ambition, no expectations.
- The foot section of the original guide on pump.zuerich is fine — follow it.

Age matters

You don't teach a 62-year-old the same way as a 5-year-old.

- **Children** stand up from the knees much earlier. Their balance recovers fast, their fear of falling is lower, and their bodies are light on the foil.
- **Adults, especially older adults**, benefit from more belly and knee repetitions. The glide feeling takes longer to settle into the body.

Read the student. The 20–100 range covers most people, but it's a range — not a rule.

Exceptions

There are always exceptions:

- **Elite athletes** (think Andri Ragettli, David Hablützel level): three belly tries and three knee tries are enough. Then they go to the feet.
- **Impatient young students (16–25)** with good balance: you can move them to the feet earlier — *if* they want it.

The rule above is the default for everyone else.

Safety

When you crash, always hold on to the board. Protects you, protects the people around you, protects the equipment. Every crash. Every time.

One last note on the guide itself

The original Belly · Knee · Feet guide is too long and too text-heavy. Learners watch — they don't read. The next iteration needs **more videos, less text**. One short clip per stage is worth a page of writing.

Reference clip: [instagram.com/p/DY_u6dlMwi9/](https://www.instagram.com/p/DY_u6dlMwi9/)

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